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THE IMPOSSIBLE PRESS: AMERICAN JOURNALISM
AND THE DECLINE OF PUBLIC LIFE

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Finally, I thank Ellen Alt for her love.

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No more than the kings before them
should the people be hedged with
divinity. Like all princes and
rulers, like all sovereigns, they are
ill-served by flattery and adulation.
And they are betrayed by the servile
hypocrisy which tells them that what
is true and what is false, what is
right and what is wrong, can be
determined by their votes.

Walter Lippmann
The Public Philosophy

You give us twenty-two minutes we'll
give you the world.

WINS-Radio, New York

INTRODUCTION
JOURNALISM AS A TRANSACTION

In 1950 Arthur Hays Sulzberger, publisher of the New York Times, spoke at the University of Missouri on "The Responsibilities of Maturity." This is what he told his audience of professional journalists:

We have two choices. We can report, and define, and explain, in honest perspective, the great issues which are now before the world; or we can ignore and minimize these issues and divert our readers to less important, but no doubt more entertaining, matters. My vote goes for the paper that informs. (qtd. in Mott, The News in America 32)

By "the paper that informs" Sulzberger no doubt meant a journal which features important information and serious analysis. In "voting for" such a paper--a paper like his own--Sulzberger made an interesting assumption. He assumed that "a paper that informs" is a statement about the kind of journalism practiced by the newspaper. In Sulzberger's view, a paper which presents information and analysis is a "paper that informs," while one offering diverting feature stories is a "paper that entertains." But there is something missing from these otherwise reasonable

statements: the people who read the newspaper. We may be reminded here of the teacher's lament, "I taught good but those kids sure didn't learn." If Sulzberger was speaking about the undergraduate curriculum and said, "My vote goes to the course that instructs," we would hope that he had in mind the students who are to be instructed. We would hope, for example, that he would not equate adequate instructional materials with a "course that instructs." For to do so would be to show an impoverished view of education, in which the learning experience of the student is ignored while school policy and teaching strategies receive all the attention. Similarly, it is an impoverished view of journalism which states that "providing information" equals a "paper than informs."

In his remarkable little book, Origins of Western Literacy, Eric Havelock points out what he thinks to be an obvious fact: that a historian interested in literacy as a social condition must trace the history of reading, not the history of writing. Of course the point is obvious once stated; but it is easy to overlook because the history of reading vanishes as it is being made, whereas the history of writing is at least partially recorded. Havelock admits that the history of reading is difficult to recover from written records. But the prominence of writing in the historian's materials "should not be used as an excuse for ignoring" reading, he argues (18-9). A similar point can be

made about the history of journalism as a social institution. What are we really interested in when we examine the press of an earlier era? What was printed, or what was read? If our aim is more than antiquarian, the content of the press must be regarded as only a clue to a larger history: the history, not of what the press has done, but of what people have done with the press. Here is where the social significance of journalism lies: in the uses made of journalism by the people who found a use for it.

What Arthur Hays Sulzberger ignored in his remarks to fellow journalists is frequently ignored by press historians, as well. Journalism is not an activity conducted solely by journalists; or, to put it another way, journalism is communication and communication is something that takes place between people. It is not an action but a transaction. A transactional history of journalism would be a very different thing from, say, the history of newspapers. Instead of "how did the newspaper change?" the question would be "how did communication between the newspaper and its readership change?" The present study seeks to make a contribution to this second approach. It is concerned not with the press alone but with the press and the audience democracy assumes for it-- namely, the public.

It should be said at the outset that "the public" is not a thing in the world. It is not, for example, coincident with the people who read newspapers. Those

readers may be brought to the newspaper for reasons having nothing to do with their public role as citizens. Because the press may be essential to citizenship does not mean that patrons of the press are essentially citizens. They may be mostly consumers, sports fans, investors or lonely hearts looking for a little advice. But the public cannot be considered wholly apart from the newspaper either. As we shall see in Chapter One, the very idea of a democratic public has been bound up with the press since at least the founding of the American republic.

What the public is, how we ought to think of it, is the point at issue in this study. So we cannot simply give an "operational definition" of the public and proceed from there. Our interest is in the idea of the public as the body to whom the press communicates. We will attempt to examine the history of that idea as it meets up with changes in the form of the newspaper and in the communication environment generally. Thus we are interested not only in the public as a body of citizens but in public life as the atmosphere in which that body is assumed to conduct its business. Our method will be to compare what is said about press and public with what we can discover about the way the newspaper has communicated at different points in its history. Do statements about press and public reflect the way the newspaper communicates? Or do they distort and ignore the communication transaction sponsored by the press?

Do they take into account the changing conditions of public life? Or do they pass over those changes and assume a communication environment which may no longer exist?

In posing these sorts of questions, we will be particularly interested in the most common assumption about made about press and public: that, by presenting information, the press "informs the public." One way to define the study that follows is to call it a critical review of the meaning and validity of this assumption, conducted at different points in press history.

The study is divided into two parts. Part One is comprised of the first five chapters and is entitled "The Making of the Modern Public." It is about the challenge modern conditions pose for traditional conceptions of press and public. Here the most important development is the rise of a new press in the mid-nineteenth century. The penny papers, a cheap, popular form of journalism introduced in the 1830s, became the basis of the modern American press. We will examine the problems this new form of journalism posed for the assumption that "the press informs the public." Part Two is called "The Public and the Professionalized Press." It is about the attitude the press took toward the public as it grew into a recognized profession after the turn of th century. Included are the ideas of two outstanding critics of that attitude, who are



also the two most important thinkers on the subject of press and public, Walter Lippmann and John Dewey.

Chapter One inquires into the origins of the idea that the job of the press is to inform the public. Chapter Two introduces the revolution in journalism caused by the penny papers. Chapter Three examines the utopian ideas about press and public which arose from that revolution, particularly after it absorbed the invention of the telegraph. Chapter Four examines an opposite tendency: the dark view of the masses which the popular newspaper inspired. Chapter Five attempts to explain some of these developments by focusing on a peculiar fact about the modern public: that it is gathered together without actually meeting. Chapter Six, which begins Part Two of the study, traces the rise of the professional attitude in journalism after the turn of the century, paying particular attention to the way in which the public was construed by an emerging profession of journalism. Chapter Seven examines Walter Lippmann's view of press and public, contrasting it with the professional attitude. Chapter Eight does the same for John Dewey. Finally, the conclusion takes up the question: how should the public be thought of today?

There is one more point which needs to be made before beginning the study. The press will be equated with the newspaper press throughout most of the study, although

television is frequently brought into the discussion. There are two main reasons for this. First, for most of the periods discussed television would not yet have made an appearance. Second, the origin of ideas about press and public is all in the history of the newspaper press. A new vocabulary for discussing press and public has not accompanied the rise of television, which is an interesting fact in itself. In any event, the study hopes to show that certain weaknesses in common assumptions about press and public are even more glaring in the case of television, a point which will be explored later in the study.

We begin, then, with the following question: how did the notion arise that it is the function of the press to inform the public?

PART ONE

THE MAKING OF THE MODERN PUBLIC

CHAPTER ONE

DEMOCRACY AND DISTANCE

The idea that the function of the press is to inform the public appears to come from democracy itself, to be a kind of deduction one is entitled to make from the premise of government by the people. As Frank Luther Mott, the senior historian of American journalism put it: "Whenever the ultimate decisions depend on the will of the people, it is obviously necessary, if these decisions are to be made intelligently, that they should be based on adequate popular knowledge of events and conditions" (News In America 5). The press, of course, is the means by which an "adequate knowledge" of public affairs is to be gained, and on that basis freedom of the press is said to be essential to democratic government (Siebert et al. 5).

But why should the issue arise whether people have "adequate knowledge of events and conditions," and why should the press--specifically, the newspaper--be put forward as the answer? How does the problem of "informing the public" originate, and what is it about newspapers that makes them the obvious solution?

News: a function of distance

These questions may seem simple-minded, but even a passing acquaintance with the history of the press shows they are not. For example, before the penny papers of the 1830s, newspapers provided almost no local news (Mott, American Journalism 51, 197; Schudson, Discovering the News 27-28). Deaths, marriages, shipping data and an occasional murder were the only exceptions; there was almost no coverage of public affairs, no enterprising reporting on town government or regular exchange of opinion on local issues. And yet "government by the people" existed at the local level-- indeed, the small town that meets to discuss its problems and conduct its business is our most vivid image of democracy at work. Why is it that a newspaper vigorously reporting the affairs of the local community was not necessary to eighteenth century town government?

The answer, of course, is that the size of the community naturally made for an "informed public." People could see with their eyes and hear with their ears most everything they needed to know (Schlesinger 60). As the New England Courant said of an occurrence on the streets of Boston, "There were too many spectators there to make it now a piece of public news" (qtd. in Mott, American Journalism 51). It is only when the community reaches a certain size, and events unfolding in one section are unlikely to reach another, that news distributed through a newspaper becomes in any way a necessity.

The point can be stated more generally: News arrives from a distance. It crosses the space between individuals and events. As the German communication theorist Karl Knies put it, "News is the communication of an event which occurred away from the location of the recipient" (qtd. in Hardt 82). It follows, then, that the history of news is a history of the "awayness" of things, a story of those changes in the scale of social organization which create gaps between people and events. News and newspapers have no vital role in a community until the distances which create a demand for news are themselves created and worked into the scale of daily life. So it is not democracy as a principle that demands an enterprising press, but democracy extended over distance-- in a word, a republic. And "news hunger" is not, as Mott contends, "fundamental in human nature" (News in America 1). People begin to hunger for news when events extend out beyond the sense of sight and the normal progression of word of mouth. The first people to hunger for news in this way were the Romans, whose empire extended far beyond the reach of the spoken word. Political economist Karl Bucher, another German scholar with an interest in news, observed that

Only when Roman supremacy had embraced or subjected to its influence all the countries of the Mediterranean was there need of some means by which the ruling class who had gone to the provinces as officials, tax-farmers and in other occupations, might receive the current news of the capital. It is significant that Caesar, the creator of the military monarchy and of the administrative centralization of Rome, is regarded as the founder of the first contrivance resembling a newspaper. (qtd. in Hardt 104)

The Sociologist Helen MacGill Hughes makes the same point in analyzing the origins of news: "Whenever trade and government has taken men away from home, the successful prosecution of their affairs has required them to know what was going on in their head offices. This is the condition that makes news imperative and gives it value and which, in the first place, gave rise to its regular collection" (2). So the first function of news is not to "inform the public" but to keep centers in touch with margins. Before anyone thought to publish (or demand) a newspaper there were professional letter-writers who kept statesmen and wealthy merchants informed of events in distance places. News was for those who controlled empires.

The Imagined Community

When news is thought of in relation to distance, there is suddenly more to explain about the relationship between press and public. It is no longer enough to say, "The press has the job of informing the public," for an earlier question presents itself: How does a public that requires a press come to be formed? What are the conditions which put the community as a whole in the position of the statesman and merchant who must "keep in touch" through the news? In the history of the American press this point can be fixed rather precisely. It was the creation of a union out of thirteen far-flung colonies that first brought into

existence a public whose scale demanded communication through newspapers. The demand for a press to serve this new public was both an empirical fact--it spurred the growth of newspapers in the mid-eighteenth century--and a logical necessity, in the sense that representative government extended over such a distance could not be imagined without some means to inform the people of actions taken in their name. (The relationship between these two notions of "demand" is itself interesting, for it turns out that the kind of press the logic of democracy demands is not always in demand in an empirical sense, a fact to be explored in later chapters.)

The public whose scale implied a free and enterprising press was, in effect, signed into law with the Constitution. But it first began to emerge in the struggle for independence from British rule, which created a community of colonists absolutely dependent on newspapers for word of its existence. One of the problems for leaders of the patriot cause before the Revolution was a communications problem--how to "make thirteen clocks strike as one," as John Adams put it (qtd. in Schlesinger 13). The real American Revolution, Arthur Schlesinger notes, was the gradual shift in sentiment against the mother country throughout the thirteen colonies, which the war itself only capped off (4). The inhabitants of one town had to be infected with the same feeling that was rising in another, and this feeling had to

coalesce around certain abstract principles that were said to cross distance and unite all colonists-- indeed, all men. "A massive politicization of the populace was underway," Richard D. Brown observes, "Generally accustomed to some participation in local politics, people now became informed and concerned with provincial and imperial issues" (79). Here was the beginning of the public the Constitution later institutionalized: the point at which Americans began to think of themselves as belonging to an abstract union of free men, rather than as subjects of England, inhabitants of Boston, or members of a particular clan. It was not that these other identities were wiped away, but that a new one was born, what Brown calls the modern notion of citizenship. "A citizen, whatever his ancestry or personal history, was a bearer of the ideology of liberty," he notes, "Commitment to such abstractions was supplanting traditional loyalties to local villages, kinfolk and social superiors" (80).

The newspapers of the period undoubtedly played a large part in creating this commitment to an invisible community of the like-minded. Schlesinger points out that while the patriot cause had no coordinated propaganda effort it somehow managed to unite opinion across the colonies, partly because of common grievances but also because of effective communication from town to town, much of it through the newspaper. The newspaper, he notes, synthesized all other forms of protest and propaganda and encouraged their spread.

It trumpeted the doings of Whig committees, publicized the rallies and mobbings, promoted partisan fast days and anniversaries, blazoned patriotic speeches and toasts, popularized anti-British slogans, gave wide currency to ballads and broadsides, furthered the persecution of tories, reprinted London news of the government's intentions concerning America and, in general, created an atmosphere of distrust and enmity that made reconciliation increasingly difficult. (46)

At this stage the press was not yet "informing the public" but helping to create the public it would later be expected to inform-- if we mean by that public a body of citizens who require the press to "keep in touch" with events affecting their interests. For before such a body could emerge the press had to convince the colonists that they had common interests and that events in one community therefore meant something to the inhabitants of another. News of uprisings in other places enlarged the world of the colonists, creating a "need to know" which could only be satisfied by more news. Here, then, is one reason why the relationship between press and public can never be as simple as saying, "The press informs the public." Forming a public is just as likely the effect of news as informing.

To be clear on this point: The sort of public for which a press is required begins to be formed when the interests of a community are extended beyond the scale of face to face relations and the organic spread of news typical of gossip. Hughes describes the condition of the community before this extension of scale:

In the smaller world of local concerns, in the countryside, the village, and the neighborhood, gossip circulated the news of interesting events among the illiterate-- and others. Its scope was smaller, being the geographical range of the peasant and the villager. Word of mouth was its natural and spontaneous medium. It had no superstructure of professional newsgatherer and purchaser and no cash value. (4)

As we have seen, the first people to demand news were merchants and statesmen whose affairs extended far enough in space to require contact with distant events. The effect of the Revolution, then, was to extend everyone's affairs from center to margin, from a relatively self-contained world where word of mouth could prevail to a larger universe in which one's interests were being defended and attacked by proxy, so to speak. For any community a rumor of war is the always the biggest news because it threatens to extend so many lives so far in space. An event that extends the community in this fashion "makes news" in the sense that it opens up new distances for news to cross.

Without a doubt the greatest news making event ever was the signing of the Constitution, which instantly made the inhabitants of the American states citizens of a nation. The dimensions of the new nation and the form of government envisioned for it implied a whole range of new distances across which news would have to travel. Suddenly one had to elect national leaders, debate national issues and keep in touch with events unfolding at a distant capital (Brown 97). It would be another century before the full implications of

national citizenship were felt, but what the Revolution had begun the Constitution institutionalized: a world in which every citizen had not only political interests but political duties extending far beyond the local community-- a world which could only be reached through the news. To get some idea of the Constitution's effect, imagine today a document making every person on earth a citizen in a democratic world government. Think of the new bureaus that would have to be opened up, the number of journalists that would now be in demand, the new range of "issues" that would require public attention, the interest one would have to take in events that literally did not exist before. Think of all the opinions one would have to have!

Public and republic

The framers of the Constitution (and their opponents) were aware that a public of unprecedented scale had suddenly been brought into being (Brown 91). And so the question arose: Was the new nation too big to be governed in the manner provided for in the Constitution? In The Federalist No. 14 James Madison decided to consider that question directly. Those who doubted that the Constitution could function over such distances were confusing a democracy with
 1
 a republic, Madison argued.

As the natural limit of a democracy is that distance from the central point, which will just permit the most remote citizens to assemble as often as their public functions demand, and will include no greater

number than can join in these functions; so the natural limit of a republic, is that distance from the centre, which will barely allow the representatives of the people to meet as often as may be necessary for the administration of public affairs. (qtd. in Meyers 133)

The United States do not exceed the natural limit of a republic, Madison contended; and to prove it he went on to calculate the number of miles the most distant representatives would have to travel. His proof of the republic's viability assumes that when the boundaries of a democracy are pushed out from the local community to a larger territory, the crossing of distance becomes the limiting factor. For the republic to be workable, Madison reasoned, transportation had to be good enough to enable representatives to meet as often as necessary.

But the territory separating legislators was not the only distance a republic opened up. There was also the distance between representatives and their constituents, between a new national government and local communities that before had been largely self governing. Moreover, this distance was a mental as well as a physical fact: being out of sight, the republic could easily be out of mind as well. Here it was not transportation but communication that determined the "natural limit" of the republic. A free and enterprising press would be required to cross the gap separating a national government from the daily lives of citizens. Madison drew this conclusion in his arguments

against the Alien and Sedition Laws of 1798, which threatened to give the national government broad powers of censorship. Is it not obvious, he asked, that the government should be restrained from regulating the press in any manner, considering "the peculiar distance of the seat of its proceedings from the great body of its constituents; and the peculiar difficulty of circulating an adequate knowledge of them through any other channel?" (qtd. in Meyer 336) With the creation of a federal republic, the problem of communication thus progressed from how to make "thirteen clocks strike as one" to how an adequate knowledge of government was to be distributed across the "peculiar distance" of the new nation. The strategic question of uniting the colonies against the crown became the larger issue of informing the people, not for action against a common enemy but for the important duties of citizenship.

Government: a homespun affair

We have so far discussed the creation of the public as a legal entity. Yet almost everyone who has thought seriously about the nature of popular government has thought it wise to point out that laws creating "government by the people" do not create people who are willing or able to govern themselves (Becker 48). Henry Steele Commager, for example:

Madison's observation that ultimate reliance must be not on "external principles" but on the "internal structure" of government was profound, but even it did not penetrate to the heart of the matter. Ultimate reliance was on the virtue, the intelligence, and the sophistication of the people." (emphasis in original; 235)

The Constitution may have signed into law a public of unprecedented scale; but the people who were to form that public were obviously not the creation of legal documents--they were products of their history. To ask, then, how the idea of a public originated is also to ask about the culture of eighteenth century America. It is to inquire into "the virtue, the intelligence, and the sophistication of the people" as cultural facts (rather than legal premises.) Obviously an adequate cultural history of the period is beyond the scope of the present study. The most that can be done here is to observe what others have observed about the character of the people who formed the first newspaper public, and to suggest some historical reasons for assumptions that were made about them.

In writing Democracy in America, Alexis de Tocqueville declared his subject to be, not democratic government, but what he called "custom," meaning the cast of mind and the type of character democracy tends to produce (1: 299). Expressed finally in law, democracy in America was at bottom a cultural condition, a way of life made possible by the peculiar circumstances of the country's growth and preserved in the habits and expectations of the people (1: 322). The

story of that way of life has been told many times:

American democracy originated in the small settlements of the New World, where people came together to clear the land and form a government among themselves, pledging to protect the public order and work in common for the common good. Unhampered by tradition yet forced by the harsh environment to cooperate with each other, the early settlers tempered an independence of mind and spirit with a strong sense of social duty, a love of liberty with a practical knowledge of government, a dedication to principle with the difficult lessons of frontier living. The delicate balance finally achieved by the Constitution was preceded and made possible by this balance of traits in the character of the people, without which, Tocqueville believed, no democratic government could be safe (1: 325).

Of all the achievements America might parade before the world, Tocqueville said, the one to be truly admired was the way in which the Constitution was adopted, a triumph of invention and restraint "at a solemn moment, when the national power abdicated, as it were, its authority." The glory of the American Revolution has been largely imagined, he wrote; many nations have performed more valiantly in time of war.

But it is new in the history of society to see a great people turn a calm and scrutinizing eye upon itself when apprised by the legislature that the wheels of government are stopped, to see it carefully examine the extent of the evil, and patiently wait two whole years until a remedy is discovered, to which it voluntarily submits without its costing a tear or drop of blood from mankind. (1: 113)

No law could have produced such patience and common sense, Tocqueville observed. The only way to account for the miracle of the Constitution was to note the course American democracy had taken from its beginnings in the self governing town to the final formation of the republic. In Europe, he noted, government had "commenced in the superior ranks of society and was gradually and imperfectly communicated to the different members of the social body." But in America, "the township was organized before the county, the county before the state, the state before the union" (1: 40). This peculiar history allowed a model of citizenship originating in the local community to progress in a similar fashion from town to state to nation, leading the historian Carl Becker to observe that Americans have always considered government "essentially a homespun affair, a convenient committee appointed by the people to perform certain specified communal services" (16). Anyone could serve on the committee, for all were competent to understand the needs of the community and skilled at solving problems. John Adams said of America before the Revolution that its division into townships, each empowered to "assemble, choose officers, make laws, mend roads and twenty other things, gives every man an opportunity... and makes knowledge and dexterity at public buisness common" (qtd. in Commager 128). Much of what we still mean by "the public," the very language we use in discussing "public opinion" and the

"public mood," shows the trace of America's small town origins. The image of a competent, informed community of citizens has been adapted to describe ever larger political units, from the colony to the nation to the entire world. As we will see in later chapters, this tendency to speak of larger structures in terms of a village environment has also shaped ideas about the press and its functions.

Work and the rights of citizenship

For Tocqueville, the belief that the art of government could be practiced by all was one of the identifying features of American democracy. It governed expectations at every level of social intercourse, from the family to the nation to the state (1: 418). What was so novel about the idea was not the principle of self-government, which the Greeks had enacted in the polis, but the extension of that principle across longer distances than antiquity could ever have imagined. We have already examined how the American republic stretched across the physical territory of the states. But it also stretched across certain social distinctions that had been essential to the concept of self rule in antiquity. Upholders of the patriot cause frequently compared the American experiment to that of the Greeks (Commager 103). "What Athens was in miniature, America will be in magnitude," said Tom Paine (qtd. in Commager 36). But while the Greeks allowed every citizen

the right to participate in public affairs, they also limited the class of citizens to a privileged minority. The most important privilege was freedom from work and more generally from the realm of necessity. As Hannah Arendt observes in The Human Condition, the Greeks believed that those who were forced to work could never be free citizens of the state, for the laborer shared with lower creatures the limitations imposed on his condition by the body (24). Citizenship, of course, was an activity of the mind. The equality of citizens in the polis was therefore created by the massive inequalities in Greek society. Freedom to reason and legislate were literally the products of slavery, and the political realm was a protected assembly of equals "in which neither rule nor being ruled existed" (Arendt 31).

The colonists may have been inspired by the Greeks (and some, of course, did own slaves), but the American experiment with democracy was of a very different character. The average man was presumed able to participate in government. In order to be a citizen he did not have to be "freed" from work or the struggle to advance in the world. Citizenship could be practiced in one's spare time, so to speak. Endowed by nature with reason and the right to govern himself, the common man could enter the political realm whenever necessary, sure of his skills and his standing there. True, the founding fathers limited the rights of citizenship to property-owning adult white males,

but these property-owning adult white males were nonetheless not the members of a leisure class. They worked for a living, and also found time to govern themselves. This is a combination that would not have occurred to the Greeks. As John Dewey observes, "Aristotle could not conceive of a body of citizens competent to carry on politics consisting of other than those who had leisure, that is, those who were relieved from all other occupations, especially that of making a livelihood" (Public and its Problems 138).

Today, the familiar "man in the street" interview shows how naturally we equate the rights and duties of citizenship with a busy life of labor. The man in the street is in the street because he is on his way to work or returning home. Pausing to give his opinions on the issues of the day, he feels no hesitation in passing from private concerns to the realm of politics and public affairs. For Arendt, this is a distinctly modern attitude; the Greeks would have found the passage impossible (31). It is important to note that news is what makes the citizen-as-worker idea feasible. News appears to allow working people knowledge of events which their work prevents them from witnessing. It is news that passes through the man in the street to come out in the form of opinion. Here, then, is another sense in which the public created by the Constitution logically demanded a free and enterprising press. In ancient Greece, what citizens "do" is act like citizens together. (Arendt 177). They

speak and listen; they make their appearance in the polis before an audience of equals in order to exercise the supremely human faculty of reason. In America, citizens have always had other things to do; they enter the political realm when it becomes necessary to act politically--characteristically, to vote. A public that works at business other than public business creates a mental distance between private life and public affairs. Across this distance news travels. "Informing the public" as an essential function in a democracy therefore arises when the title of citizen is extended to those who labor at duties other than citizenship; or, to look at it another way, when the work of the world is distributed from the laboring classes to the ruling classes so that sharp distinctions between the two begin to dissolve. Thus, Tocqueville concluded that the press becomes more important as social conditions become more equal (2: 114).

Jefferson's dilemma

The citizen as a worker who takes time out for politics is today represented by the man in the street, but in the eighteenth century the ideal was the man in the fields. Both Madison and Jefferson thought farmers were the hope of the republic because the nature of their work demanded a general competence and gave every man a stake in the preservation of order. "Cultivators of the earth are the most valuable citizens," Jefferson wrote in a letter to John

Jay, "They are the most vigorous, the most independent, the most virtuous, and they are tied to their country, and wedded to its liberty and interests, by the most lasting bonds."² Jefferson believed that "such men may safely and advantageously reserve to themselves a wholesome control over their public affairs, and a degree of freedom, which, in the hands of the canaille of the cities of Europe, would be instantly perverted to the demolition and destruction of everything public and private."³

While in principle every man was considered able to participate in government, in practice some lives made for better citizens than others, Jefferson thought. The environment of the city was hostile to the health of the republic because it introduced into social relations the "casualties and caprice" of trade, crowded people together in relations of dependence and generally corrupted the body politic by making some people subservient and others wildly ambitious. "The mobs of the cities add just so much to the support of pure government, as sores do to the strength of the human body," he concluded in his Notes on the State of Virginia.⁴

The view of the city as crowded and corrupt has a long history in Western thought, and there is nothing particularly distinctive about Jefferson's version of it. What is significant is his realization that the conditions which encouraged a competent and independent citizenry were,

after all, impermanent, capable of being undone by social changes no one could control. In an introduction to Jefferson's writings John Dewey amplified this point. The American experiment with representative government benefited from many fortunate accidents and acts of providence, Dewey wrote. These included the wide ocean separating America from Europe, the Anglo-Saxon tradition of liberties which did not have to be discovered anew, the many competing religions which prevented a single church from dominating, the great stretches of land and rich resources which allowed freedom of movement, the independent spirit developed on the frontier, and so on. Jefferson understood these advantages, Dewey observed, "Even so, he had fears for the future when the country would be urbanized and industrialized, though upon the whole, he says, he tended by temperament to take counsel of his hopes rather than his fears" (Living Thoughts of Thomas Jefferson 19-20).

As almost everyone knows, Jefferson's native trust in the people was also coupled with a desire to improve their minds through education. In his Second Inaugural Address, he told his audience to "bear in mind this sacred principle, that though the will of the majority is in all cases to prevail, that will, to be rightful, must be reasonable." ⁵ Of course, it was not the burden of education to bring reason to the masses but simply to bring it out, for Jefferson was a child of the Enlightenment who believed that ⁶ reason was God's design revealed in the nature of man.

Though the good sense of the people would emerge in the long run, he believed, there would always be errors and false steps along the way. The way to prevent them from becoming too serious was to give the people "full information of their affairs through the channel of the public papers, and to contrive that those papers should penetrate the whole mass of the people."⁷ The press, then, was part of Jefferson's plan for improving the minds of the people, and he stuck to this plan even though the newspapers of his day⁸ performed scandalously, in his estimation.

Jefferson's reputation as an upholder of press freedom and an advocate of popular education is certainly deserved, but its bulk tends to overshadow another approach he had to improving the public mind. This was to limit the size of the world which that mind had to judge. The way he proposed to do this was to divide each state into small political units resembling the New England parish. These would be so limited in scope that every citizen would feel responsible for their administration and would gain the experience of self government in a practical way. The small units Jefferson called wards:

Each ward would thus be a small republic within itself, and every man in the State would thus become an acting member of the common government, transacting in person a great portion of its rights and duties, subordinate indeed, yet important, and entirely within his competence. The wit of man cannot devise a more solid basis for a free, durable and well-administered republic. (qtd. in Dewey, Living Thoughts 39)

In Jefferson's scheme the wards would be given as much of the work of government as they could reasonably manage, passing on whatever larger responsibilities remained to higher political units such as the county, state and nation (Adams xiii). Dewey notes that it was the extension of the scale of government past the dimensions of local life that Jefferson wanted to minimize at all costs-- not "government" (or the Federal government) per se (22). The danger was a machinery that exceeded the grasp of the average man's mind. That mind could be taught to grasp more, but just as important was the need to keep the demands on it modest. This is an approach to "informing the public" which has had very little force in American thought. The idea that "keeping the public informed" means more than providing information, that it could also mean limiting the range of things the public has to be informed about, has rarely occurred to anyone other than Jefferson, for whom these things went hand in hand.⁹ Late in his life, Jefferson said there were two subjects he would "claim a right to further" for as long as he was alive: "the public education, and the sub-division of the counties into wards. I consider the continuance of republican government as absolutely hanging on these two hooks."¹⁰

The reason for this long digression into Jefferson's thought can now be made clear. Jefferson believed that "informing the public" would be a difficult task even for a

scrupulous press free of government interference. The difficulties concerned not only the performance of newspapers--which Jefferson found atrocious--but also the composition of the public and the dimensions of the world it had to be informed about. His first and most famous solution was to educate the people and to encourage a flow of information to them through the press. But his second solution was more interesting: to somehow preserve a world whose citizens were self informing. That is why he admired the farmer's world so much, and that of the New England towns: they produced competent citizens by their very nature. The farmer was the ideal of the independent citizen, the New England parish that of the independent community. What both were independent from were the conditions which extend the scale of the community and make it dependent on news. Both, in other words, were bulwarks against the "awayness" of things.

In attempting to preserve these worlds Jefferson was in effect reversing the logic of the republic whose future he had so much in mind. For as his friend Madison recognized, the very idea of a republic was that it extended the "natural limit" of the self contained town. In a similar way, Jefferson appeared to be holding back history when he suggested that America should remain a nation of farmers and "keep our workmen in Europe" by importing rather than¹¹ manufacturing whatever goods were needed. Trade and

industry, the growth of cities and the reach of a national government over the heads of citizens were all on the horizon, and since he was not blind to these facts Jefferson had a third solution to the problem of "informing the public"-- faith. The people were to be educated, their public duties limited in scope as long as possible, but in the end they were simply to be trusted, for the only alternative to trusting their good sense was force (Dewey, Living Thoughts 18, 24).

As a champion of the press Jefferson is an odd figure indeed. For he sought to preserve a scale small enough to require no press at all. He did so not because he distrusted the press (although he did), but rather because he understood that if an "informed public" existed in his day, it existed not as a result of a free press, but as a social condition, a way of life made possible by certain advantages Americans had enjoyed. As a social condition it could pass from the stage of history; and it would pass, he thought, if the open spaces filled up and the country became urbanized, or if the scale of government outgrew the grasp of the average man.

Communication as cause and cure

For the present study, the important points are two: first, that all the possibilities Jefferson feared actually came to pass in the second half of the nineteenth century;

second, that their coming is what enabled the press to grow into a powerful institution touching everyone's life. The mobs of the city may have threatened the health of the republic, but they were the ones who purchased newspapers when the modern press began to emerge in the mid-nineteenth century. Industrialization and urbanization may have done away with the generally competent citizen and made for a population of dependents, yet the same forces made mass production of newspapers a possibility-- not only by introducing the machinery necessary for large circulations, but also by spurring the growth of the advertising which financed the development of the modern newspaper. Similarly, the gradual expansion of Federal responsibilities undoubtedly made for a less informed public, in the sense that the scale of the national government grew too large to relate easily to daily life. Yet this same growth made the press an indispensable part of national politics and gave American journalists a permanent function in government which the rest of the world still finds astonishing. As the world of the small town and the independent farmer disappeared from American life, so did the possibility of assuming a naturally informed public composed of competent citizens who could and did make the "ultimate decisions," as Mott put it earlier in this chapter. If such a public ever existed, it was not the one the press was to address when it began to assume its modern shape in the 1830s.

Like Jefferson, Tocqueville understood that the conditions favoring the American experiment with democracy were impermanent, and when they changed the character of citizenship would change as well. He predicted the difficulties Americans would have when their world outgrew the secure environment of the small town:

The country then assumes a dim and dubious shape in the eyes of the citizens; they no longer behold it in the soil which they inhabit, for that soil is to them an inanimate clod; nor in the usages of their forefathers, which they have learned to regard as a debasing yoke; nor in religion, for of that they doubt; nor in the laws, which do not originate in their own authority; nor in the legislator, whom they fear and despise. The country is lost to their senses; they can discover it neither under its own nor under borrowed features, and they retire into a narrow and unenlightened prejudice. (1: 242-3)

Tocqueville is simply saying that as the nation grows bigger, it becomes "lost to the senses" and citizens begin to understand it, not on its true scale, but according to the limited horizon of their personal experience. We are accustomed to thinking that the press can prevent this retreat into ignorance and prejudice. After all, is this not the function of the free flow of information, the reason we give special protection to the carriers of news? Is it not the purpose of a free press to breach the gap opened up between the scale of the nation and the "self-informing" village environment? What the present chapter has tried to show is that the bridging of such a gap is not simply a matter of providing enough information to keep people in

touch with distant events. For the situation is more complex than that. Prior to the precious functions of news in a free society, news is function of other things, especially the extension of the community's affairs in space. The doctrine of a free press would obviously insist that, as the nation grows bigger and more complex, the function of the press is to restore the shape of the country in the eyes of its citizens, and to do so accurately and fairly. But the press is also a function of the changes which give the country a "dim and dubious" shape in the first place. And so is communication in general.

Here we come upon an intriguing problem in press history and communication theory. As communication media are called on to inform the citizen of events he cannot witness himself, they are simultaneously involved in enlarging the world of unwitnessable events. We have already seen how this worked during the Revolution. By spreading word of rising sentiment against the mother country, the press helped create a community whose interests extended across the colonies and whose status could only be told through the news. News of the Revolution created a revolution in the need for news. The same was true for printed material in general; it enlarged the world of the colonist and brought word of an enlarged world. Tocqueville, for example, pointed out that while the press helped to create a world of political equals, it also

provided a voice to those lost in its midst. "Equality sets men apart and weakens them," he wrote, "but the press places a powerful weapon within every man's reach, which the loneliest of them all may use....Printing has accelerated the progress of equality, and it is also one of its best correctives" (2: 324-25). In a similar way, it might be said that communication enlarges the problem of an uninformed public even as it appears to provide its solution. Perhaps the clearest example of this dialectic at work will be examined in future chapters: the growth of the telegraph, which brought news of distant events while at the same time making such distances a fact of life.

Summary

This chapter began by arguing that news is a function of distance. A public which requires a press to "keep in touch" therefore cannot be assumed to always exist. Instead, it arises when the community's affairs are extended over a distance across which news must travel. In America such a public was formally brought into existence by the Constitution, which gave every citizen political duties extending far beyond the local community and its organic methods for informing the citizen. Eighteenth century America had good reason to believe that its citizens would not be lost in the wider environment of the republic, for the way the country was settled had bred independence and

competence into the character of the people-- or at least the belief in these. Among the results was the notion that every citizen was capable of governing not only himself, but the community as well, since government was basically a "homespun affair." This idea persisted despite the fact that, unlike the Greeks, Americans have always had work to do other than the work of citizenship.

But the conditions favorable to a competent citizenry were social conditions, which meant that they were subject to change. Jefferson in particular had fears for the day the country would become urbanized and industrialized, and he tried [^]preserve a smaller scale by building into the structure of government a limit on the demands of the average man's mind. His idea of the ward was an attempt to imagine a political unit for which a press would not be necessary, a community small enough to be self informing. This was almost an order for history to stop, for Jefferson could see that an urban, industrialized country and a large and distant national government were all coming to pass. The irony is that their coming is what enabled the press to grow in size and prestige, which suggests the intriguing possibility that the conditions undermining a naturally competent public are also those making for a powerful press.

This more or less reverses the way we are taught to think about press and public. We are taught to equate a stronger, larger and more widely available press with a more

informed public, but it may be that the arrival of one brings the decline of the other. A more developed press and a less informed public may go hand in hand, not because this new press prints lies or leaves out information--the perennial concerns of press commentary--but rather because "informing the public" involves more than the facts necessary to be informed. It involves the world one is to be informed about and the scale of events in that world. In the next chapter this line of thought meets the arrival of the modern newspaper.

CHAPTER TWO

TWO VIEWS OF NEWS

History presents a most fortunate fact to the student of American journalism: the sharp line separating the modern newspaper from its predecessors. Neither the meaning nor the cause of the revolution of the 1830s is entirely clear, but that it was a revolution is beyond dispute. Within a few years the newspaper had transformed itself from a special interest journal serving a limited class of merchants and public men to a mass medium capable of reaching every citizen in the community. From a selling system which priced a copy of the paper at six cents available only to yearly subscribers came a street sale system which delivered the paper everywhere in the city for the magic price of a penny. The staid business of stock prices, ship schedules, speeches and official announcements gave way to sensational accounts of murders and scandals, outrageous invasions of private worlds, offbeat sketches of everyday life and a general tone of wonder and amusement that had been completely absent from the journalism of the day.



Incredible as it seems, local news was almost unheard of in the six cent journals; it took the penny papers of the 1830s to discover that people wanted to learn about events in their own environment. Advertisements in the commercial press were long and dull and frequently went unchanged for weeks at a time; it took the penny papers to declare that ads were a form of news, and therefore had to vary each day to be interesting. Reporting was virtually an unknown art; the penny papers discovered that news had to be found by men who knew where to look. Finally, the huge circulations of the penny press provided the capital to finance astonishing feats of newsgathering that began to bring the ends of the earth in contact with one another.

The changes begun by the penny papers marked out the course American journalism was to follow into the twentieth century: more and more enterprise in the gathering of information, the development of a specialized reporting profession, the gradual decline in the influence of the editorial and a rise in the importance of news, the increasing independence of the newspaper from politicians and political parties, bigger and bigger circulations made possible by new methods of mass appeal, and with those circulations an increasingly rationalized advertising system that became the financial footing of the newspaper. As Michael Schudson points out in Discovering the News:

There were rural papers, hundreds of them, but the papers which set the standard for journalism then and passed on their legacy to the present were urban.

There were party papers, there were socialist papers and labor papers, there were business papers, but, again, the papers to which modern journalism clearly traces its roots were the middle-class penny papers. (60)

Given the importance of the penny press, one might expect to find a number of explanations competing among historians for the right to rule textbooks and guide future inquiry. One might anticipate different schools of thought on the question of why the cheap papers emerged when they did, each leading to a different view of the modern newspaper. By now there should perhaps be a revisionist history of the penny papers, or several such histories. One finds almost none of this. It is not that a single explanation dominates the field, leaving students of the press free to tackle other problems. What characterizes the field is an aversion to large organizing concepts which would connect the progress of news and newspapers to broader cultural patterns. Much of journalism history is simply a chronicle, in which the major events seemingly cause themselves.¹

It is significant that Frank Luther Mott thought it necessary to say in the introduction to his standard history of the press that "the only safe generalization about journalism is that no generalization about it is safe" (American Journalism vii). The same might be said for any area of social inquiry. One is always faced with too many particulars, too much that can never be known and too much

knowledge that can never be assimilated. To mention such a commonplace is merely to restate the problem of the scholar sitting down to write: no generalization is safe. So why would a writer mention it, if not to announce an intention to avoid the problem of generalizing? In coming across Mott's remark, Schudson was correct to point out that "no generalization is safe, but we live by them and with them" (Discovering the News 42). Similarly, in an article criticizing the timidity of press historians, Allan Nevins observes that "the superabundance of jumbled, disparate and mainly trivial details in the files places on the writer a burden of assortment and synthesis under which most men break down." But press history is so thoroughly connected to the movement of larger social forces that one has no choice, Nevins argues. If the student of journalism "does not fix on the right principles of selection and synthesis he might as well throw himself into a vat of printer's ink" (413).

But what are the right principles? According to James Carey, the way to discover them and to cure the defects of press history as a whole is to reconstrue the development of the press as a chapter in a larger, only partially written history of how people have made sense of their world. In an essay on "The Problem of Journalism History" Carey writes:

Journalism is essentially a state of consciousness, a way of apprehending, of experiencing the world. The central idea in journalism history is the "idea of a report" and the changing notions of what is taken to be an adequate report of the world. Because we are a

news saturated people it may seem strange to argue that the desire to know, understand and experience the world by getting news or reports about it is really a rather strange appetite. (4)

Carey's suggestion is to "de-naturalize" the demand for news. Instead of seeing news as an obvious necessity, something humans require each day as they require sleep or food, we can ask how it is historically that most people come to demand a daily newspaper. Here the penny papers occupy a critical place in press history, for they not only popularized the press, putting a daily paper in the hands of the common man for the first time; they also set in motion the development of the modern newspaper, chiefly by discovering the popular appeal of the human interest story.

In the first chapter, we concluded that news is a function of distance; it arises as a social necessity when the scale of events in a community is extended beyond the reach of word of mouth. We then posed the following problem for the relation between press and public: the extension in scale which gives birth to news as a social artifact is also the eclipse of certain advantages American democracy enjoyed in its formative period-- in particular, the rooting of politics in a local, mostly agrarian environment where every citizen could grasp the meaning of political events and feel like a participant in them. In this chapter we delve further into this contradiction by examining the rise of the penny papers. Our goal will not be to simply describe changes in the form of the newspaper but to connect these to changes in

the scale of everyday life, especially to the rise of the city, that environment whose character and size Jefferson feared. If it is true that the rise of the press is also the decline of a village environment and the political life it allowed, then there should be a sense in which a bigger, more powerful, more modern press means a less informed, less active, less capable public-- not because the information carried by this new press is unreliable or incomplete compared to its predecessor, but rather because the conditions making for an informed, competent public are not primarily characteristics of the press. They are social conditions involving the "awayness" of things. What relation did the penny papers have to the "awayness of things?" That is the question the present chapter addresses. Here history does the student of the press another good turn. The penny papers did not appear everywhere at once but only in the largest cities, and first in New York, the largest. The initial connections, then, will have to be between the city as a human (and, in certain important respects, inhuman) environment and the newspaper as a report (and a part) of that environment. Let us see where this approach takes us.

The breaking apart of the common world

In 1784 William Bradford, a Philadelphia printer and the proprietor of the Merchants' Coffee-House, announced that his establishment would provide a new service.

To prevent the many disappointments that daily happen to returned citizens, or others, enquiring for friends, connections, or those that they may have business with; the subscriber has opened a book, as A City Register, alphabetically arranged, at the bar of the Coffee-House, where any gentlemen now resident in the City, either as a housekeeper or a lodger, or those who may hereafter arrive may insert their names and place of residence. (qtd. in A.M. Lee 46)

What Bradford was offering was a form of news-- word of who was in town and where they could be reached. While central meeting places like inns and taverns had always provided such information, they had done it through word of mouth. New in town, a stranger would wander in and inquire after his connection. The need for a written register arises when there are too many connections, too many strangers, too many arrivals and departures for the community to maintain through speech and memory a record of its inhabitants. Here is a fundamental condition of city living: no one knows who the inhabitants are, or, at any given time, where they can be found. What held for people also held for ships. For years Bradford had kept a log in which captains could enter their names, the names of their vessels, the port from which they sailed and any other information which might interest merchants (A.M. Lee 46). Such a log becomes necessary when a port grows to a certain

size and its traffic becomes too heavy, its day too busy for each ship to be sighted or for news of its arrival to spread through word of mouth. The need for news in these examples arises from conditions of ignorance (or, as Bradford put it, from "the many disappointments which daily happen to returned citizens") created by the scale of the city as a human environment.

Urbanization represents a kind of breaking apart of the common space in which people once dwelled, a division of the community into many separate worlds which the city dweller may or may not inhabit at different times throughout the day. Thus, where people once worked and lived within sighting (or shouting) distance of any arriving ship, in the city they begin to lose this totality of vision; a public event is no longer public in the same way for all. That the space of the common world has been split apart is obvious to us when we look out over the city from a tower or skyscraper. The thrill of the panorama is the restoration of a total view; the city is suddenly intelligible again, and we can connect the parts to make a whole.² But to get such a view we must abandon the streets for the tower: back on the ground the panorama dissolves, the common world breaks apart into the private space of each inhabitant. What happens to space happens to the social group as well. It can no longer keep track of all the inhabitants and pass judgment on their actions, a fact which has always made the

Today, the unraveling of the central city into far-flung suburbs is undoing the logic of the city newspaper. Papers based in large cities are losing circulation to the suburban dailies, which are based closer to where people live. This shift has already spelled the death of the afternoon newspaper in most major cities (Smith, Goodbye Gutenberg 30-31, 69-71).

Separating the news from the newspaper

What William Bradford discovered was that the scale of commerce in Philadelphia had created the need for new forms of news. Because of the new distances governing daily life connections had been broken, meetings missed; merchants were operating without the knowledge they needed. Bradford also understood that Philadelphians in need of this news were near enough to each other to meet at a central place-- the Merchants' Coffee-house. Nearness to, ignorance of: these are the conditions of city life that make possible new forms of journalism.

The historical significance of the coffee-house is that it offered a variety of daily journalism before the appearance of the daily newspaper. Bradford himself was a printer and the publisher of a weekly, the Pennsylvania Journal. One suspects he would have gone to a daily if he thought the city could support such an enterprise. While his coffee-house began its news service to merchants in

1754, the first dailies did not appear until 1785, after which they gradually took over the journalistic functions of the coffee house (A.M. Lee 45). The interval of thirty years suggests one point where the history of the news departs from the history of the newspaper.

Let us be certain the distinction is clear. News is a social artifact. Wherever there are distances of a certain type governing everyday life, a need for news is created. The German economist Karl Knies noted that emigration always steps up the flow of written communication because it extends the family unit in space and creates a new demand to "stay in touch" (qtd. in Hardt 84). This is an example of the social conditions to which news is a response. The letters which pour across the seas in time of war are also a rudimentary form of news, created by the same conditions which require businessmen to learn of distant events which may affect their interests. The problem news solves is therefore a social problem, having to do with the contact human beings must maintain with an environment extended in space. Newspapers, on the other hand, are an outgrowth of the printing press. The first problem they must solve is an economic one: how to produce a product whose sale will at least offset the cost of printing the paper (Hardt 104). Different solutions to this problem have given us different forms for the newspaper: the party press is one solution, the commercial journals for the merchant class another, the

mass circulation newspaper another, and so on.³ To simply furnish the news has never solved the economic problem of the newspaper. There has always had to be something else-- government printing contracts, political party subsidies, advertising revenues, all of which have helped to support the basically unprofitable business of gathering and distributing news. In this sense there has never been an independent press.⁴ To find exceptions to this rule one must reduce the newspaper, which circulates generally, to the news-letter, which circulates privately. Since the seventeenth century there have been wealthy patrons willing to pay enough for news to offset the costs of its collection and transmission, but part of what they are paying for is exclusivity-- the fact that the news is not published.⁵

Once the social problem of news has been separated logically from the economic problem of publishing a newspaper, a new way of interpreting the significance of the penny papers becomes possible. For the penny press was a revolution in both news and newspapering. New forms of news were introduced and a new form for the newspaper was invented. The social problem involving contact with an extended environment was solved in a new way, while the economic problem of supporting the capital costs of the printing press also gained a new solution. The factor essential to both revolutions was the density and scale of the city.

The logic of local news

With the rise of the city a new fact entered daily life and revolutionized journalism: the immediate environment became unfamiliar. This is what the six-cent journals had not fully understood. They served a class of readers, mostly political men and merchants, whose affairs were extended in space in the traditional sense. The political man, for example, naturally looked to the capital for the latest news. Historian James Melvin Lee notes that among political newspapers the "most important piece of news was always a report of the official proceedings of Washington." Ignoring events in the local community, the editors of political papers would publish the routine details of Congressional debates, often printing long-winded speeches verbatim. They "evidently thought that which came from Washington had additional news value because of its source," Lee observes (145). The businessmen was similarly interested in news from afar; his investments were bound to be affected by events he was not able to witness or hear about in time. It was simply in the nature of commerce to produce this sort of need for news, for as Marshall McLuhan once observed, "Money is action at a distance, both in space and in time" (Understanding Media 136).

An early hint that the immediate environment had become unfamiliar came with the coffee house, whose log recorded nearby events that had escaped the notice of the merchant.

This was the beginning of local news, which before had been a contradiction in terms. The logic of local news originates in the urban paradox: the fact that the city's inhabitants are near to but yet distant from events unfolding around them. The daily newspaper began when it became economically feasible to publish the local news previously available at the coffee house. Its first function was to provide merchants with up-to-date shipping news and prices current, information which came from the very streets on which the merchants walked (Mott, American Journalism 118). The first dailies thus took advantage of those special conditions the urban audience shares: proximity to, ignorance of, each other. But as we have said several times, these papers were limited to a certain class of readers. What the success of the penny papers eventually demonstrated was that merchants were not the only city dwellers isolated from events unfolding in their immediate environment. This had become a general condition of urban life, and it could therefore provide the logic for new forms of news and--because the new audience was so large--a new solution to the economic problem of the newspaper. Let us examine the revolution in news first.

What was so different about the kind of news the penny papers presented? To begin with, it was aimed at a different sort of reader: the mechanics, artisans and shopkeepers, members of what Schudson calls "a rising middle

class," who found little to interest them in the commercial and political journals (Discovering the News 56). These readers had been excluded from the established press not only by subject matter but also by price. As Issac Pray noted, "Even slander was slow in sale at sixpence" (184). Part of the formula for the penny papers was borrowed from the London Morning Herald, which had built a huge circulation in the 1820s by featuring humorous sketches of police courts and sensational accounts of criminal trials (Mott, American Journalism 22; Bleyer 156). The New York Sun, the first successful penny paper, combined these borrowed features with short, sprightly items of local interest, often with a moral lesson stated or implied, together with shocking accounts of prodigies and monstrosities. Editorially, the Sun delivered its opinion on such topics as public drunkenness, dueling and gambling, the sort of "issues" that were likely to interest its readership (Bleyer 164). The contrast with the sixpenny papers was dramatic; they had been dominated by shipping news, stock prices, reprints of speeches and elaborately argued editorials called "leaders," part of the in-fighting typical of party politics at the time.

The penny papers were an immediate hit. The Sun appeared on September 3, 1833, and within four months had a circulation of 5,000, more than any other paper in New York. From this point on the cheap press would far outdistance its

rival in circulation, achieving levels undreamed of by the six cent journals: over 20,000 in 1836, 30,000 in the 1850s and 60,000 in the 1860s (Mott, American Journalism 222, 234, 237).

Human interest: a childish desire?

How to account for the miracle of the penny press? Edward P. Mitchell, the Sun's editor-in-chief, attributed the paper's success to "the abolishment of the conventional measures of news importance" and "the substitution of the absolute standard of real interest to human beings" (qtd. in Bleyer 303). Let us examine what this means. In practice there is no doubt about what it meant: a deliberate shift away from politics and public affairs, which, of course, had been one of the mainstays of the sixpenny journals. It has frequently been observed that the penny papers declared themselves independent from political parties, and almost every opening prospectus for a cheap paper goes out of its way to make that point; but this generalization, while true, understates the case considerably. In word and deed the penny papers declared themselves independent not only from political parties but from politics itself, from the assumption that political affairs had an automatic claim on people's attention. As Bleyer observes:

Day dismissed briefly, or entirely excluded, political news, the doings of Congress and of the state legislature, the political speeches, as well as editorials on political and economic questions, to

all of which the sixpenny papers devoted most of their space. In the matter of politics, the Sun, like most of the penny papers that followed it, was not only neutral but quite unconcerned. (160)

In the first chapter we heard Jefferson argue, in one of his most famous statements on the press, that "the people are the only censors of their governors." They may err, Jefferson wrote, but the only way to prevent their errors from becoming too serious was to "give them full information of their affairs through the channel of the public papers, and to contrive that those papers should penetrate the whole mass of the people." To reach the point where it did, in fact, "penetrate the whole mass of the people," the newspaper of the nineteenth century had to reject politics and public affairs. It became the popular medium Jefferson envisioned only by abandoning the functions he had envisioned for it. (And it could take this step only because of the scale and character of the city, the environment Jefferson thought would be the ruin of the republic.) Thus, the image of a public informed through newspapers, so vivid to democrats then and now, is something of a mirage in press history. It is difficult to square with the means by which the press actually began to reach a general audience. As Bleyer observed, the secret of the Sun and its imitators was in "appealing to the emotions of the masses, rather than to their intellects..." (164). This was surely not what Jefferson had in mind.

Yet as soon as we have said this a problem presents itself. The simple opposition between the emotions and the intellect, the instincts and the intelligence, the irrational and rational sides of man--a theme found throughout press history and, indeed, through much of Western thought--threatens to prevent any understanding of how the methods of mass appeal actually function, and how they differ, as communication, from the sort of news that is said to "inform" people. A cloud of pejoratives hangs over the forms of news popularized by the penny papers, indeed, over those items in the press of any period that are merely "interesting" rather than "important." In her study of the human interest element in journalism, Hughes writes, "Human interest is the interest of the laymen. It is, moreover, the interest of the unsophisticated, the young and the childish" (215).

Using these terms, it is easy to explain the success of the penny papers in the 1830s, or the "Yellow Journalism" of the 1890s, or something like People magazine today: most people are not mature enough to demand the higher forms of journalism. They require the immediate and therefore childish satisfactions of human interest stories, refusing, because of temperament, upbringing, or sheer lack of self-control, to develop adult habits of reading and thinking. They would rather "let themselves go," as Schudson has phrased this opposition, rather than "control

themselves" by reading of politics and public affairs.⁶ As
 an 1896 editorial in the Nation put it:

The note of the press today which most needs changing is childishness. Even if the papers are clean and decent, they are fit only for the nursery. The pictures are childish; the intelligence is mainly for boys and girls. The "good stories" are trivial, and are intended chiefly for junior clerks and laborers. The observations on public as distinguished from party affairs, are quite juvenile. The abuse is mostly boyish or street abuse, with neither rhyme nor reason to it. What is wanted in the way of reform is mainly maturity, the preparation of the paper for grown people engaged in serious occupations. Gravity either in discussing or in managing our affairs is fast vanishing under the journalistic influence. We laugh over everything; make fun of everybody, and think it will "all come out right in the end," just like ill-bred children who hate to have their games interrupted. (356)

Under this sort of reasoning, the press would improve if journalists and readers would begin acting like grown-ups. The weaknesses of mass journalism are moral weaknesses, a giving in to temptation or a refusal to face up to adult responsibilities. As a sociological understanding of the methods of mass appeal, this view obviously has severe limitations. In the end it is not all that different from "explaining" structural unemployment by referring to the laziness of the unemployed.

Just as the information the press provides (or fails to provide) is not the determining factor in whether the public is informed, neither is the maturity or temperament of the citizen a sufficient explanation for how well the press informs the public. In both cases, what needs to be

understood are the social conditions which give rise to different forms of news and govern their uses. In the case of the penny papers and the human interest story, we need to ask what the communication functions of the human interest item are in a city environment: what do these stories do for people? And we need to ask how the social utility of the merely "interesting" differs from that of information.

The journalist as dramatist

What exactly is a human interest story? Let us take a typical item from the Sun's popular police court sketches and see how it works.

Catharine McBride was brought in for stealing a frock. Catharine said she had just served out 6 months on Blackwell's Island, and she wouldn't be sent back again for the best glass of punch that ever was made. Her husband, when she last left the penitentiary, took her to a boarding house in Essex St., but the rascal got made at her, pulled her hair, pinched her arm, and kicked her out of bed. She was determined not to bear such treatment as this, and so got drunk and stole the frock out of pure spite. Committed. (qtd. in Mott, American Journalism 223)

What is of interest here? What makes this a reportable item? The typical Sun reader would not know Mrs. McBride, nor really care about what happens to her. She is not a member of a community small enough to have an interest in the conduct of each of its members. Although the item sounds like gossip, its functions are very different. Gossip communicates what is known but cannot be told about the members of a community. It is a kind of adjustment

mechanism which releases the pressure on public appearances by providing a common but more or less secret means of distributing knowledge incompatible with the "front" people maintain for friends and neighbors. In Erving Goffman's terms, gossip is "backstage" talk which has the function of keeping "front-stage" performances apparently free from scandal (106-140). In a village environment, the "keeping up" or maintenance of appearances is a function the entire community performs in order to stay together as a community. For when a life is damaged by publicity, many other lives are affected: a family history is at stake, and that family's history is connected to everyone's else's, all of them reflecting, for good or ill, on the reputation of the town and thus on the self-image of each of its members. In this sense every town is "our town," a place where everyone's business is "our business." Because gossip threatens so deeply the health and history of the community its characteristic expression is a whisper. What is a whisper? Speech without voice, content from which the distributing power of a medium has been withdrawn. Gossip, then, can never be published: that is what makes it gossip.

But in the city the terrible power of gossip dissipates. Strangers do not hold over one another the community's power to judge. Lives are not intertwined in precious histories to which every family has contributed. A domestic tragedy is not a tragedy for everyone but only for

those directly involved, and these poor souls form a tiny minority. "Detachment is therefore achieved in the city," Hughes remarks, "where even the deepest tragedies are events in the lives of persons unseen and quite unknown to the majority of readers" (150). (Thus, the penny papers were the first to publish the names of bankrupt persons, an unthinkable act in a village environment.) In a small town newspaper, Hughes notes, the "human" behavior of animals is often the subject of human interest stories, for animals "have no interests and no reputations" to protect (152). In the city, where the people involved are not known to each other, the item of gossip can safely be published. But its social functions then change. Where it once served to maintain social order by releasing pressure on appearances, it now dramatizes the social order by presenting symbolic instances of its collapse and restoration. As Robert Park puts it, the incident "ceases to be a record of the doings of individual men and women and becomes an impersonal account of manners and life" (Society 93). Here "impersonal" means "symbolic." The information is no longer important as information; it does not tell people about events in particular lives. Instead, it becomes material for a little domestic tragedy. The wife becomes all wives, the drunk all drunks; the particular begins to signify the typical. As the information in gossip changes functions and becomes the material of art, what had been a community of

participants with an interest in the outcome of events is also transformed. The community of actors becomes an audience whose interest is that of a spectator at a play, waiting to see what will happen on stage.

The archtypal human interest story is a crime, not because a fascination with crime and criminals is "fundamental in human nature," as Mott would put it, but because the nature of drama is that it requires an incident, a disturbance, a conflict, some departure from the procession of ordinary events whose outcome will provide the occasion for telling a story. Even if the night is relatively peaceful the journalist as dramatist will hunt down some odd incident or disturbance. For one cannot dramatize the peace without first having it broken in some way. As a writer for the North American Review noted in 1885:

A million people behave themselves, but that is no news. Nobody thinks of reporting that, of saying anything about it. But if one contemptible man, any miserable tramp, anywhere in America, commits a meanness, they not only note the fact, but tell us all about it. (Savage 152)

The complaint here is an interesting one: a million instances of law-abiding behavior go unnoticed, while one crime gets all the attention. When the function of news is to inform people about actual conditions "out there" in the world of events, the million-to-one ratio is a measure of inaccuracy. The news has failed to bring an empirical truth

to light-- the fact that most people behave themselves. But when the function of news is essentially dramatic, the same ratio becomes the very logic of the form: it is exactly the million-to-one relationship which makes the crime of interest. And it is interesting not as a description of social reality but as a dramatization of it. Thus, the press, as the Review notes, must "tell us all about it." Indeed, the telling is the point of the exercise. For only as the tale is told do we learn that Catharine McBride got drunk and stole the frock "out of pure spite." Only then is our dramatic interest satisfied. (The deferral of this satisfaction, the elimination of the event as the starting point for drama and its resolution as the end, is what made Beckett's Waiting for Godot such a radical idea for a play. sp By staging a drama in which "nothing happens" Beckett upended the logic of the theatre, thereby revealing its apparently natural forms as historical conventions whose time, he thought, had come. At an earlier stage of press history waiting for events to occur was a common experience, not one a dramatist had to provide. Publick Occurrences, the first newspaper published in America, announced on September 25, 1690 that it would appear monthly, "or, if any Glut of Occurrences happen, oftener" (qtd. in Mott, American Journalism 9). Whether something would happen was still a question in 1690-- chances were it would not. The daily newspaper could not appear until the city offered an

environment in which something was always happening, with the police court as the one place where "a glut of occurrences" was sure to collect. That something has happened, that the pattern of stillness has been disturbed and action taken in the world, that each day, each hour, will inevitably bring its news-- this is the deepest and most basic assumption in modern journalism, amounting almost to a form of faith. The teletype machines clattering away in the newsroom reaffirm this faith, telling anyone who happens to be around that events are constantly unfolding. Were the machines to grow silent the only possible explanation would be a mechanical failure: that the world might stop producing events is unthinkable. Even more than theatre, the conventions of journalism depend on the inevitability of something happening, of the surface being disturbed. Thus, the news is to said to "break." That it will break is the premise on which a modern press is built.)

The old newsroom formula, "when dog bites man, that's not news; when man bites dog, that's news" illustrates the dependence of the news on the variation from routine. Man biting dog provides the occasion for dramatizing the fact that ordinarily it is dogs that go around biting men. Other news items published in the Sun exhibit the same logic. Reports on a child prodigy or a man with seven toes are extremely direct ways of dramatizing the ordinary limits of human ability or, in an even more basic fashion, the normal

design of the human body. Again, the appetite for these tales is not fundamental in human nature like the sex drive or the hunger for food. It develops historically, and until we have a social history of human amusements we will not understand fully why it developed when it did. Yet if there is something fundamentally human about these items, it is the way they allow meaning to be made. Here we can simply mention the structuralist insight that meaning, in language and in everything else, is constructed by the play of differences.⁷

Information and the need to act

What have we said so far? That human interest items may superficially resemble an item of gossip in a small town but in fact have a very different function in a city. That function is to dramatize the social order by telling a story about its disturbance. The information in the story is not important because it refers to actual people and their movements in the world of events, but rather because it provides the material for the art of the human interest item. It literally "makes a good story." A good story will always involve some disturbance or break in the pattern of ordinary events not because journalists (or their audiences) are perverse, but because journalists are acting as dramatists and the nature of drama is to begin with some such break. Thus one writer's formula for news: "News is

any event which varies from the reader's picture of the normal and accustomed world" (Irwin, Propaganda and the News 47). It can be argued that meaning in general requires a conflict, an opposition, something to create the play of differences. A crime is the typical human interest story since it represents a kind of generic instance of the surface being broken: a "disturbance of the peace" in its most basic form. The crime story does not empirically describe social reality but furnishes the material for enacting a drama about it. H.D. Duncan calls this type of ritual a "sociodrama," which, for modern man, is typically mounted through the mass media. In the sociodrama mounted by crime, the values of the community are given life, made meaningful to people, through the symbolic threat posed to them by the criminal. For Duncan, the sociodrama demonstrates that "people do not want information about, but identification with, community life. In drama they participate" (34).

Information about, identification with-- two types of news, two uses for information, two different roles for the journalist, two attitudes toward the world on the part of the audience, two kinds of communication. These are the distinctions we need to make in understanding the significance of human interest news and the revolution of the 1830s, not the simple opposition between a child's

desires and an adult's. Let us explore these distinctions further.

We have already observed a number of times that the need for news arises when events unfold at a distance. Implicit in this understanding of news has been the connection between information and action. Word of events unfolding at a distance is necessary in order to adjust action to the current state of affairs. Thus, the wealthy merchant and the statesman are the first to require news because they must control action across the space of their empires. But the human interest item makes this connection between information and action problematic. As Park observes in the introduction to Hughes's book,

Items like these are interesting not because there is anything to be done about them, not anything that is urgent enough at any rate to require a revision of one's attitudes. On the contrary they are merely suggestive and seem to project us out of the world of temporal and local affairs into the timeless world of ideas and fancies. (x)

The reason the human interest item seems to exist in a timeless realm is that its meaning resides not in a series of events unfolding "out there" in the world, but in the relationships among the participants and events internal to the story. Roland Barthes makes this point in an essay on what is called in French a fait-divers, which for us is a filler item. Barthes asks us to consider two murders, one a political assassination, the other an ordinary street crime.

In the first, (the assassination), the event (the murder) necessarily refers to an extensive situation outside itself, previous to and around it: "politics"; such news cannot be understood immediately, it can be defined only in relation to a knowledge external to the event, which is political knowledge, however confused; in short, a murder escapes the fait-divers whenever it is exogenous, proceeding from an already known world... Thus an assassination is always by definition partial information; the fait-divers, on the contrary, is total news, or more precisely, immanent; it contains all its knowledge in itself; no need to know anything about the world in order to consume a fait-divers; it refers formally to nothing but itself... ("Structure of the Fait-Divers" 186)

Barthes goes on to show how this internal meaning-making (or "immanence") operates in a typical filler item. The item announces that the Palace of Justice has just been cleaned ("That is insignificant," he notes, not even worth an inch of space) for the first time in more than a century. "That becomes a fait-divers," he concludes. Why? Because the two facts, the cleaning of the Palace on the one hand, its infrequency on the other, work together to make for a little story; they create an intelligible meaning, (the way figure and ground make each other intelligible) which can then be elaborated upon. It is this simple structure which identifies the logic of the filler item, not any reference to a larger world of events. "What matters," Barthes says, "is not the terms themselves, the contingent way in which they are saturated (by a murder, a fire, a theft, etc.), but the relation which unites them." Since it is the odd or irregular relation between two facts

which brings the filler item into existence, there can be no simple fait-divers, constituted by the persistence of a regular, expected fact. Some break or eruption is required. "The simple is not notable," Barthes concludes (187). Thus, the prodigy and the crime, two basic forms of variation from the expected or persistent pattern, are in Barthes's scheme the typical filler items (189).

Of course, the "important" news of the world, the news we think of as serious and informative, also requires an event to be told. In this sense it is no less dependent than the filler item on some variation from routine. But here the event obtains its meaning in a different way. It is interpreted in light of its relationship to an ongoing situation. Hughes observes that this sort of news "is a phase of action" defined by what comes before and after. "It enters at a crucial moment when something is in process, still unfinished and to be acted upon in the immediate present by a revision of actions or attitudes" (58). But in order for news to function as a "phase of action," (whether this action is material or mental) more than the item of news is required. This is what Barthes meant in saying that political news is always "partial information." An understanding of the events that are "in process" is required for the item to become a piece of information. To be informed by a piece of news one must already be informed enough to know why a piece of news is news: the item itself

is not enough. Hughes notes that followers of a sport or experts on the stock market share this status.

The news is meaningful to the fan and the expert as symptoms are to a physician; he takes account of it by revising his attitudes or by planning practical measures to meet it almost as soon as he has heard it. But when the reader does not know how to act, the news is sensational. (62)

Symptoms are meaningful to a physician because he has a structural understanding of the human body which allows him to give "events" like a hacking cough or a chest pain some place in an overall picture of a person's health. Symptoms become symptoms of something only in light of this ordered knowledge which predates the event. For the baseball fan the ordered knowledge consists of the rules of the sport, which make the reports of games played the previous day meaningful. In a similar way, the follower of the stock market knows how the market works: particular events like the day's prices can therefore have a meaning. In addition to this structural understanding--the means to know--the fan, the expert and the physician have a need to know. They feel themselves participants in an ongoing situation: the pennant race, the investment business, the health of a patient. To participate they must act and revise their actions in light of new information. (That is how one "follows" a pennant race, for example.) These actions may be symbolic; they may involve a change of mind or a revision of attitudes. The essential characteristic is not their materiality or concreteness but their contingent quality,

the need to continually revise, refigure, reimagine the status of things in light of the latest information about them.

Rethinking the idea of information

This is a mode of being in the world which is anything but natural. People have not always felt a sense of urgency about events, for they have not always understood their world as continually in need of revision. Nor do they necessarily feel this way just because they are presented with the information necessary to act on the feeling. The first people to experience the world in this way were the statesmen and merchants who controlled empires extended in space. The need to control action at a distance is the first and surest demand for news as information. That is why commerce and war have been the spur to most of the advances in newsgathering. And that is why governments and corporations today spend large amounts of money to gather news that would not interest a mass audience. A history of the demand for news would have to include a history of this feeling of controlling action at a distance through a steady supply of fresh data, and the still incomplete spread of that feeling from emperors to ordinary citizens. To trace the development of such an attitude would help begin the project James Carey spoke about: the reconstruction of press

history as a study of how "the idea of a report" came to establish itself in modern consciousness.

In the seventeenth, eighteenth and into the nineteenth centuries, news was commonly referred to as "intelligence," which, as Anthony Smith notes, was information

passed on from one person in the know to another, a term that contained overtones of diplomatic knowledge garnered in high places and sent along reliable routes to the offices of the editor. "Intelligence" was passed from the well-informed to the well informed. (Goodbye Gutenberg 163)

To equate news with information is so common and natural that it is easy to overlook how much information is required for news to function as information. Strictly speaking, no one has ever understood anything about the world by reading newspapers. Rather, one reads newspapers--if one reads for information--because one already understands the world and wants to update that understanding by adding fresh data. For the news to perform a function anything like "informing the public," the public must share at least three things. One, a structural understanding, an ordered knowledge which enables individual events to be placed in some sort of meaningful relation to an ongoing reality; two, in addition to the means to make meaning, the need to do so, some feeling of participation in or control over events that would require a continually updated awareness of the world; three, the element of contingency, a situation in which outcomes are not wholly predictable, where the event, when it occurs, signifies the

separation of the actual from the merely potential. Thus Park notes that typical news items like births, deaths and weddings always make news, since they "are the expected things," but "at the same time the unpredictable things" (Society 82). Structure, action, contingency-- these are the three conditions necessary for news to function as information. The more people who participate in these conditions the bigger the item of news becomes. In an interesting aside, Hughes remarks that, theoretically, the biggest piece of news imaginable is the end of the world (61). Here is an "event" which impinges on everyone's ordered understanding of the world, which affects everyone's actions and which is totally unpredictable. Thus the recent parody of the New York Post which featured the end of the world as the lead story. The headline: "Kaboom."

A more common example is provided by the weather. Everyone understands enough about it to interpret a weather prediction and everyone feels involved enough with the weather to have at least a vague interest in its outcome. That is why the weather is the ultimate conversation maker: if two people do not have that in common they are literally living in different worlds. Membership in the community of weather-watchers and competence in that community is virtually automatic. Also, the weather retains an element of unpredictability about it: each day the actual must be distinguished from the merely potential. Thus, the weather

is the only story that appears on the front page all the time and a weather disaster is always urgent news for the community involved. But notice what happens when one of our three conditions is absent. News of a weather disaster in a far away place removes the element of participation: it is no longer "the weather" above our heads but someone else's weather, and it no longer requires a revision of plans the way the local weather might. And yet it may be still be interesting. A new way of participating in the news thus presents itself. The questions are no longer "how will I get to work?" or "how should I dress today?" but "where will the people go now that their homes are destroyed?" and "how will daily life be restored?" in short, "how will the story come out in the end?"

This sort of interest in events has undoubtedly been encouraged by improved communication technologies, which bring news from far away places without bringing the conditions necessary for news to function as information. In fact, they may undermine those conditions, by, for example, heightening the feeling of powerlessness over distant events. Any history of the press which focuses on the expansion of the information-gathering network is therefore incomplete unless it also examines changes in the ability of the audience to receive information as information. What is really needed is a revamped understanding of what information is, or rather, where it

can be located. We are accustomed to thinking of information as something that is "in" the news, as long as the news is relatively complete and accurate. But it is perhaps wiser to think of information as being "in" any social context which gives to updated reports the quality of making a difference for future action. Again, war is an archtypal case. War creates a context in which any piece of data can be information, because so much is riding on every change in the status of events. The prevalence of rumors during wartime testifies to the strength of war as an information-creating context; rumors turn everything into information, even data that is unreliable or made up.

Drama vs. structure

Where news retains the connection to action, relatively minor events make a difference and are still of interest. Locally, the arrival of a rainstorm is news, since it is somewhat unpredictable and may affect the daily lives of the inhabitants. But when news loses the connection to action and people participate merely as spectators the minor event is no longer interesting. It is only the spectacular weather disaster which warrants the designation of news for people outside the locality: a rainstorm in Louisiana has no news value anywhere else. The more distant the connection to decisions made in daily life, the bigger and more dramatic the event must be to hold any interest. This is

the root of sensationalism: not a perverse appetite for the crude and spectacular, but the increasing difficulty of interesting a population which does not act on its world in a way which requires a constant supply of fresh information. In sensationalism, one of the three conditions necessary for news to inform people predominates-- contingency. The odd, the unexpected, the spectacular are news simply because they depart from the norm. So while it is true that all forms of news depend on the event, some forms are more dependent than others. Where there is no need to act on the basis of fresh information the event carries the whole burden of newsworthiness, and must therefore inflate itself to absurd proportions. At the opposite extreme is the equally absurd world of the paranoid, who believes that everything that happens affects his fate and, in his delusions of grandeur, sees his own actions as monumentally decisive. Insanely connected to a contingent world, the paranoid interprets every event, no matter how trifling, as news: everything makes a difference. Just the opposite condition gives rise to sensationalism: the difficulty of making a difference.

To take an interest in the dramatic and the spectacular is one form of contact with the world, one way of learning about what is happening "out there." One assumes the role of the spectator at a play or a passing parade, (a form of interaction for which television later becomes the ideal medium.) The film critic Stanley Cavell, in discussing

television's weakness for the spectacular, observed that the bias of the medium alone does not explain this tendency. More than television's preference for pictures and action is involved.

For what would have to be explained... is exactly our continued attraction by events, our will to understand our lives, or to take interest in them, from their dramas rather than from their stabilities, from the incident and the accident rather than from the resident, from their themes rather than from their structures-- to theatricalize ourselves. But this is something that Thoreau, for one, held against the interest in reading newspapers a century and a half ago, an interest he described as amounting virtually to an addiction. (92)

What needs to be explained, Cavell suggests, is why people choose one form of understanding over another; why they prefer drama over structure, the odd twist in the offbeat over a stable understanding updated by fresh data. As he notes, the problems raised by this choice begin not with the carnival atmosphere of television but with the rise of the newspaper as a mass medium. If the dramatic appeal of the human interest story was behind the success of the penny press, then what explains this "will to understand" the world through drama as opposed to structure?

Symptoms and symbols

To answer to this question we will have to examine further the three conditions necessary for news to function as information: structure, action, contingency. The first is an ordered understanding of the world which allows events to

be placed in relation to one another and therefore to refer to an unfolding reality "out there." There are many ways to illustrate this idea. In baseball this ordered knowledge consists of the rules of the game. In the stock market it involves a basic grasp of the principles of finance and a knowledge of how the market operates. In medicine the analogy can be made to the physician's structural understanding of the human body which allows various "events" in the health of the patient to take on medical meaning. In politics it might be the content of what was once called "civics," that is, a grasp of the structure of government. A political ideology consciously held could also provide this sort of framework for interpretation. In each case the important feature is a relation between structure and event which allows the event to take on meaning as a symptom of a changing situation. The simplest example of this sort of relation involves the interpretation of sense data. Thunder becomes a symptom of rain because humans have learned to associate one with the other. Before that learning takes place there is no information value to thunder. (Indeed, we might say that the sound of thunder is at that point merely sensational.) Perhaps the most complicated relation between structure and event is found in language, where the speaker's knowledge of grammar allows individual "events" occurring within that language to take on meaning. Again, without this structural grasp of the

principles of the language the information value of events approaches zero. Thus we say that a strange language "makes no sense."

When news functions as information it resembles what Susanne K. Langer calls a "natural sign."

A natural sign is a part of a greater event, or of a complex condition, and to an experienced observer it signifies the rest of that situation of which it is a notable feature. It is a symptom of a state of affairs. (emphasis in original; 57)

That news is a symptom produced by the situation is the root of all claims to objectivity. Whether the situation is a natural one (like the weather) or a human artifact (like the stock market), news is thought of as an outcome of an organic process that produces the event irrespective of the actions of the observer. Here again the weather is the most basic form of news because it literally is a natural sign, whereas other situations are merely treated as natural systems. Thus, a day of trading on the stock market "naturally" produces the prices which are a symptom of the progress of the market and the economy as a whole. As we have said, the interpretation of these signs depends on the ordered knowledge of the observer (Langer 58-9). But their production does not. In this sense the news "breaks" each day as naturally as the light of morning. It arises from the day's activity, not from the actions of journalists. All notions of objectivity begin with the non-involvement of the journalist in the process that produces signs. In the

same way that a doctor does not "produce" the hacking cough he notices in a patient, the journalist, it is thought, does not produce the events about which he furnishes reports. We will of course have reason to question this assumption when we examine the reporting profession in future chapters.

In contrast to news as sign (or symptom) is news as symbol. The function of a symbol, Langer argues, is to make possible not a reaction to an event but a conception of it. Symbols allow us to think about things when the things are not present. "Signs announce their objects" to the perceiver, she writes, "whereas symbols lead him to conceive their objects" (emphasis in original; 61). The referent for a symbol, then, is not an object or event in the physical world but the human conception of it-- that is what the symbol "means." The difference between sign and symbol involves the second criterion necessary for news to function as information: the need to act. For signs are a prelude to action. They indicate the present state of affairs for those who must act and revise their actions in light of new information. Symbols, on the other hand, are tools for contemplation outside the sphere of action. They enable thought and meaning and all the symbolic functions of art to arise. The human interest item functions not as a symptom of the underlying state of affairs, but as a symbol of human behavior. It is not a prelude to action but an occasion for thought or feeling, an opportunity to sympathize with

Mrs. McBride, whose husband "kicked her out of bed" and who then got drunk "out of pure spite." What the human interest item symbolizes is not an unfolding world of events, each contingent on the other, but the human comedy played out again. Gossip, on the other hand, is a sign: it announces what is happening in the community and invites a revision of attitudes in light of new information.

The historical problem raised by the penny papers can thus be phrased in a new way. If it is true that the rise of the cheap press is also the rise of the human interest item, of the "interesting" over the "important," and of news as symbol over news as symptom, then what needs to be investigated are the social conditions which produce a need for one as opposed to the other. When do people need symbols? When do they need signs? Part of the answer has already been provided: they need signs when they are actors in a situation that is constantly changing. Signs inform them about the present state of affairs and invite a revision of attitudes or actions in light of that information. When people perceive themselves as actors in such a setting they will tend to demand news that functions as a sign. But when do they need symbols? Specifically, what is it about urban life in the mid-nineteenth century that would produce a need for new symbols? And how is it that the mass circulation newspaper came to furnish those symbols?

The city as passing spectacle

In his introduction to Hughes's study of the human interest story, Park observed that: "One may, in an idle moment, read the newspaper with the same interest that one looks out the window at the moving throng in a crowded street" (ix). The comparison is a useful one. In the newspaper the world passes by like a parade, inviting the eye of the spectator to fall on whatever captures its fancy. This is a mode of involvement typical of city life and particularly the life of the streets. The world is experienced as a passing spectacle, which offers a wonderful variety of forms and styles and an infinite amount of detail to be taken in and decoded. One participates, but as a spectator. The great boulevards of Paris were designed in the mid-nineteenth century with just this sort of experience in mind. The critic Marshall Berman writes:

What did the boulevards do to the people who came to fill them? Baudelaire shows us some of the most striking things. For lovers, like the ones in "The Eyes of the Poor," the boulevards created a new primal scene: a space where they could be private in public, intimately together without being physically alone. Moving along the boulevard, caught up in its immense and endless flux, they could feel their love more vividly than ever as the still point of a turning world. They could display their love before the boulevard's endless parade of strangers--indeed, within a generation Paris would be world famous for this sort of amorous display--and draw different forms of joy from them all. They could weave veils of fantasy around the multitude of passers-by: who were these people, where did they come from and where were they going, and what did they want, whom did they love? The more they saw of others and showed themselves to others--the more they participated in the extended "family of eyes"--the richer became their vision of themselves. (152)

Berman is quoted at length because the passage describes so many elements of the urban experience: the constant contact with strange people and the wonder and amusement they invite; the surge of power that the scale of the city, especially its architecture, sends through every resident, whatever his status; the sense of constant movement and change, of endless activity eluding the widest eyes; the fantastic surfaces of city life, available at a glance to anyone but in the end not to be deciphered, since they conceal the uncountable private worlds from which all these strangers have emerged; and, above all, the paradoxical feeling of intimacy and distance, of participating in a great project and yet have no power to direct its course, of being a party to but yet apart from the great spectacle of the city. To this experience the newspaper began to speak. In discovering the appeal of the human interest story, the penny papers were offering up the urban environment in transmuted form: the fear of sudden danger striking from nowhere encouraged by the dark streets found safe expression in the murder story and, later, in the black headline warning of crisis; the "veil of fantasy" woven around the parade of strangers was parted by the newspaper's daily accounts of domestic tragedies; the power and wealth of the city as a whole was focused on the exploits of the powerful, wealthy and glamorous people who made up "society," their private worlds now opened up for

public view by insistent reporters. The extremes of city life, high and low, took on names and dates, locations and brief histories; they were personified and thus made more real to the persons who experienced them.

The newspaper, in other words, took to the streets. For one thing, it was sold there, becoming a commodity that contributed to the urban spectacle; for another, it told the story of the streets in a public way, penetrating hidden worlds and reflecting in its own urgency the powerful sensations the city had loosed on each of its inhabitants. Smith notes that in the nineteenth century "the newspaper was a mental highway through which the imagery of the city traveled." It brought people inside the urban experience for a look around.

The newspaper's readers learned from its text the layers of status and prestige within a newly constructed society; they were daily shown the abyss of disgrace into which the criminal, the drunkard, the bankrupt, could fall. The newspaper proposed the makeshift realities of society, where no other medium of homogeneity existed. (Goodbye Gutenberg 28)

In other words, the sense of what it means to live in the city was provided by the newspaper, which summed up--symbolically--the vastness and weirdness of a world which had exploded in scale to the point where no single spectator could take it all in (Wirth 17). As the outer world lost its solidity so did the inner. The most basic facts were now things to be discovered. Who am I? Where do I place myself in this vast spectacle? How do I dress? How

do I act? How do I think of myself? Who are my neighbors? Of what community am I a member? Everything is thrown into doubt because nothing is settled and everything seems possible. In describing this aspect of city life Berman quotes a passage from Rousseau's romantic novel The New Eloise, in which the young hero moves to the city and, in an anguished mood, writes to his beloved:

I'm beginning to feel the drunkenness that this agitated, tumultuous life plunges you into. With such a multitude of objects passing before my eyes, I'm getting dizzy. Of all the things that strike me, there is none that holds my heart, yet all of them together disturb my feelings, so that I forget what I am and who I belong to. (18)

These conditions of doubt about basic issues like personal identity and one's place in the community created the need for new symbolic forms which would "inform" people, not about events in a distant environment, but about the life they were living now, in the dizzying world of the city. People were suddenly distant from themselves--in a word, they were alienated--and they needed "news" which would speak to this condition, as well as to the wonderful vibrancy of urban life and their own sense of participation in it, however slight. In his study of Robert Park and the Chicago school of sociology, Fred Matthews observes that the city "made the essential dynamics of human behavior" problematic and therefore available for viewing. "In more traditional communities," he notes, "the network of social relations was not a problem but a fact." It maintained

itself through custom. But in the industrial city "the constant conditions of strangeness, the fact that so many relationships were new, shifting and impersonal, meant that the processes of social control were no longer concealed under the cake of custom but laid bare for dissection" (121). Sociology eventually took advantage of the great social drama the city opened for view, but the journalist, says Matthews, was there first, fulfilling the role of "informal and intuitive sociologist," a human medium who acted "as eyes, ears and moral censor for the audience removed by size and distance from the direct exercise of these traditional communal roles." Where the community as a whole had once surveyed the activity of its members, giving each one his standing in the social network, the newspaper now helped perform this function and the moral duty which went with it. (Of course the two were somewhat in conflict. As the North American Review noted in 1885, "The editorials often grieve over the alleged decline of family morals, and the frequency of divorce; while, in the same issue, the reporters are left free to turn the revelations of the police and divorce courts into the juciest kind of jest" [Savage 150].) A small community could literally keep track of everyone; but in the city this was plainly impossible (Park, Society 93). The suverying of activity thus took place through symbols, people and events who stood for larger themes, who could represent the city to a mass

audience and in whom the audience could see reflected some aspect of their experience.

Summary

We can now propose some tentative answers to our pair of questions: When do people need news as sign? When do they need news as symbol? They require news as sign when they feel themselves actors in a constantly shifting world, where events take on meaning by confirming the actual happening and separating it from the merely potential. In order for news to function this way, more than information about events is required. This is why the content of the newspaper is not a sure guide to how well it "informs the public," for the "informability" of the audience involves more than the amount of information it is presented with. Events must be contingent, unpredictable; they must bear upon action and require some revision of plans or attitudes; and they must be able to be placed within some structural understanding of the environment which sets them in relation to one another. Historical changes in the sort of information provided by the press are therefore connected to larger histories that reach beyond the development of the newspaper. One would have to ask, for example, what groups of people have historically participated in the conditions necessary for news to function as information? How do broad social changes like urbanization, industrialization, and

democratization affect the composition of these groups? More specifically, what is the effect of improvements in communication technology on the number and sort of people capable of demanding news as information? How does the newspaper itself affect the spread of the conditions which make its own information functions possible? Does it encourage the possibility that people will feel themselves actors in a contingent world? Or does it inhibit that possibility by, for example, exaggerating feelings of powerlessness? Does the newspaper's coverage of world affairs educate people and expand their grasp on the environment, making it easier to place events in some meaningful relation to one another? Or does it make that process more difficult by describing events out of context and shifting from one crisis to the next?

All these questions grow out of a distinction that needs to be made explicit: furnishing information is not the same as informing people. One is a technical question involving the sending of messages. The other is a social question involving the way people act and understand themselves acting in a world that may or may not require fresh reports of its current status. Progress in solving the technical problem of sending messages has no simple relation to the conditions which make the information functions of news possible. In understanding those functions, the important question is not how much

information people have, or even "are people informed?" but rather: what makes people informable? If part of the revolution of the penny press was a shift from "information" to "human interest," then one explanation may lie in the informability of the audience. Compared to the merchants and public men who were the patrons of the commercial press, the buyers of the penny papers were not informable in the same way. They did not act in a world which required the same kind of updated reports about business, politics and public affairs, and so their news took other forms.

Those other forms we have broadly characterized as symbolic. The human interest stories of the penny press served new symbolic functions brought about by the expanded scale of the city as a social environment. It is obvious that the penny papers succeeded because a mass audience was "interested" in the stories they had to tell. But the important question is: why was that audience interested? The answer we have suggested so far is that the conditions of urban life create a new experience that is both . frightening and liberating, which throws into doubt the identity of the individual by weakening the traditional bonds of the community, while at the same time infusing everyday life with drama and spectacle typified by the boulevard's parade of passing strangers. The world widens and blooms, becoming a place of infinite possibility, but at the same time it narrows and turns back on itself: the man in the

street is encased in his own limited world, cut off from the old bonds of community and unable to command a comprehensive view of his environment. The human interest story spoke to this new fact of life. It put a wider world in the hands of the average man, giving him glimpses into lives he could not live himself, but which he could sense being lived in his midst.